book?' To which she replied, 'Have you written one yet?' I had to confess I hadn't even thought about it. Gurveen though, assured me that Penguin would be happy to consider publishing me. That set the ball rolling.

The very next day, we sat down to strategize. What to write about; autobiography or memoirs or a bit of both? How long? Timelines? The last was a major factor. If the book had to be released on some occasion—for example, Veteran's Day, which falls on 14 January each year, then the first draft of the manuscript would have to be submitted by mid-June. It was already mid-March. Were we being too ambitious? After some discussion, we thought we should give it a try. It was really up to me and deadlines only spur you on. The ball was now truly and fully in my court.

How do you write about four decades of Army life and compress it into one book? That was the real challenge. What about the childhood years? Did those shape me in any way and play a role in my life? Do they have any significance? A close friend of my wife, Shailaja, with several works to her credit, advised me not to start this self-editing even before beginning to write. She said that if there was some incident from my past that I still remembered vividly, then obviously it had some import and would have shaped my outlook in some way or the other. Write freely, she said, it will be all the more natural.

All of us have so many memories of our childhood and careers. Many of the experiences we have especially in and of the Army, about our years at the Academy, for example, are almost similar. Nothing new nor worth a repeat. In recounting these events and experiences, therefore, I have chosen those that left a lasting impression and moulded my character or outlook. The manner in which a situation was handled (or mishandled) by my superior, for instance, and the lesson learnt from it. Each

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